



BEARDED DRAGON · POGONA VITTICEPS

Keep your bearded dragon the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: setup, UVB (ultraviolet B) lighting, feeding by age, safe foods, handling and body language, health triage, the law in every state, and the routines that keep a dragon thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Heat, UVB and humidity targets in Fahrenheit and Celsius
- ✓ Safe foods charts: 70+ insects, greens, vegetables and fruit
- ✓ Health triage, symptom table and an emergency card
- ✓ Owner logs, a pet-sitter sheet and a power-outage plan

50 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

Edition 4.1 · Oct 2026



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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A dragon and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 26: a bearded dragon is legal without a permit in most of the United States, but not everywhere. Then read pages 4 to 12 in order before buying anything. Housing, temperature and UVB decisions are expensive to redo, so get the enclosure size and the lighting right the first time, and use the Budget & Shopping List on page 36 to buy once.

If your dragon is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, and go to the Red Flags page (page 27) if anything seems off. The food charts starting on page 14 are worth a read even for experienced keepers, since most diet problems come from a food that was fine "once in a while" becoming a daily habit.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 34: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 42: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 35: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 43: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 39: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 44: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 45: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Bearded dragon care has changed a lot in the last decade. This package reflects current UVB, enclosure-size and diet standards, cross-checked against the veterinary and scientific sources listed on page 48.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Pogona vitticeps</i> (inland or central bearded dragon)
Adult size	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm) nose to tail; 300 to 500 g, big males heavier
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years with consistent care
Native range	Arid woodland, scrubland and rocky desert in the central and eastern interior of Australia
Diet type	Omnivore: mostly insects when young, mostly greens as an adult (page 13)
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm, about 120 gallons), front-opening preferred
UVB requirement	A linear T5 HO (high-output, 5/8 inch) tube, giving a UVI (ultraviolet index, the strength of the UVB) of 4.0 to 4.5 at the basking spot
Sexual maturity	Around 12 to 18 months; females can lay infertile eggs without a male (page 23)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate; generally tolerant once settled
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$40 to \$100 for a standard dragon, \$505 to \$1,190 for the equipment, plus \$120 to \$245 for the first vet exam and fecal test (a stool check for parasites). Every line is on page 36.

Monthly ongoing

\$75 to \$145 for feeders, greens, supplements, electricity, bulbs and the yearly vet visit, averaged.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

Emergency care isn't rare enough to ignore: impaction surgery commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500, and MBD (metabolic bone disease) treatment \$200 to \$500 or more. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but plan for both.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The "beard" is a flap of spiny skin under the chin that darkens and puffs out during stress, territorial display, or breeding, not a sign of aggression by itself.
- They darken their backs to absorb heat when cool and lighten when warm, an effect measured in wild dragons.
- They can see ultraviolet light through a fourth type of cone cell, which is part of why lighting affects appetite and mood, not just bones.

The species, morphs, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The pet bearded dragon is *Pogona vitticeps*, the inland or central bearded dragon. It is the species the pet trade sells, and the only one this package covers. In the wild it lives in the arid and semi-arid interior of central and eastern Australia, basking on rocks and fence posts in open woodland and scrubland and eating insects, plants, flowers and the occasional small vertebrate. It is active by day and solitary: two dragons do not keep each other company, and every one does best housed alone. It takes its name from the expandable, spiny throat pouch, the "beard," which darkens toward black when the dragon is threatened or excited.

Morphs

A morph is a captive-bred line that looks different from the natural, wild-type dragon: a different color, pattern, or skin. A standard dragon costs \$40 to \$100. The care in this package applies to every morph with one exception. Hypomelanistic (reduced dark pigment), silkback and translucent morphs are more sensitive to UVB and can be burned by standard output, so their basking spot gets a UVI of 3.0 or lower instead of 4.0 to 4.5 (page 9).

Size and growth

Adult length	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm) nose to tail tip. Most healthy adults measure 18 to 22 in (45 to 56 cm).
Adult weight	300 to 500 g is typical, and large males run heavier. Frame size varies between dragons the way it does between people, so two healthy adults can sit at different ends of that range.
Growth	From under 10 g at hatching to over 300 g in about a year and a half. Most of the length comes in the first year, and growth slows sharply once the dragon reaches sexual maturity at around 12 to 18 months.
Males and females	Adult males are slightly larger, with bigger heads and darker beard displays. Telling them apart reliably takes until about 4 to 6 months of age.

Lifespan

10 to 15 years is typical in captivity with good care. Wild dragons live 5 to 8 years, because predation and disease cut them short. A dragon bought for a child can still be in the house when that child leaves home, so plan for the whole span: the routine and a reptile vet for every one of those years.

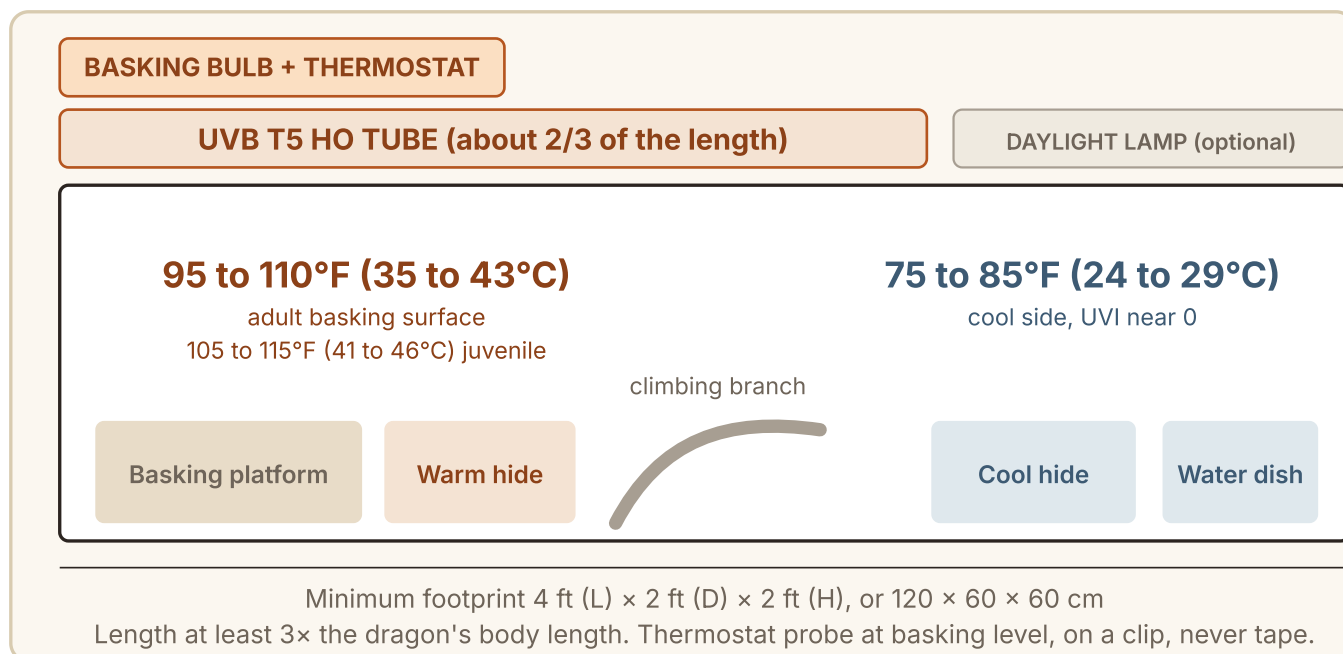
CAPTIVE-BRED IS THE ONLY KIND THERE IS

Australia banned the commercial export of its live native animals in 1982, and no legal supply has left the country since. Every bearded dragon outside Australia descends from stock that got out before or around that ban, and large-scale breeding only took hold in Europe and the United States in the 1990s. So the American trade is entirely captive-bred, with no lawful wild-caught supply. A young, captive-raised dragon makes the better pet; an older, imported animal is harder to tame and more likely to carry intestinal parasites. What to look for in the animal itself is on page 22.

Enclosure size, type & where it goes

4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm, roughly 120 gallons) is the adult minimum, not an upgrade to get around to eventually. As a rule of thumb, enclosure length should be at least three times your dragon's total body length. A juvenile-sized enclosure is outgrown within a year, so buying the adult size from day one costs the same or less than buying twice. A front-opening enclosure makes daily handling and cleaning far easier than a top-opening one.

PVC (polyvinyl chloride, a rigid plastic) or sealed wood enclosures with glass fronts hold heat far better than all-glass tanks, weigh less, and are what most experienced keepers use. A glass tank works, it just needs stronger heating to hold the gradient, and a screen top changes the UVB mounting distance (page 9).



NEVER

House two bearded dragons together. They are solitary and will stress, fight, or resource-guard even in large enclosures. Cohabitation is not "social enrichment" for this species.

Where it goes

- Out of the kitchen and away from anywhere food is made or served.
- Out of direct sun. A glass enclosure in sunlight heats far faster than the open air around it, even briefly.
- Away from heavy foot traffic, and out of sight of other pets.
- In a room that stays above 65°F (18°C) at night, if you can, so no night heat is needed.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Cover three sides to cut down on reflections. A dragon that keeps mistaking its reflection for a rival can develop chronic stress.
- Two hides minimum, one on each end, so your dragon never has to choose between security and temperature. Anchor everything an adult can climb so nothing shifts under its weight.

The temperature gradient & heat

A hot end, a cool end, and a dragon that moves between them to set its own body temperature.

ZONE	TARGET (°F)	TARGET (°C)
Basking surface, adult / juvenile	95 to 110 / 105 to 115	35 to 43 / 41 to 46
Warm side (ambient air, not the basking surface)	about 90	about 32
Cool side	75 to 85	24 to 29
Nighttime low	65 to 75	18 to 24
Humidity	30 to 40% baseline. Brief spikes after a soak are normal; days above 50 to 60% cause respiratory and skin trouble.	

Measure the basking surface with an infrared thermometer aimed at the platform, not the air. Surface temperature is what the dragon actually feels, and it is the number stick-on dial thermometers get wrong. A basic hygrometer (humidity gauge) is worth the few dollars it costs.

Two fixtures, not one

UVB and heat are separate jobs, and mixing them up is one of the most common setup mistakes. A T5 HO UVB tube gives ultraviolet light but almost no usable heat. Pair it with a separate halogen or incandescent basking bulb over the same platform, run through a dimming thermostat, and confirm the surface temperature with the infrared thermometer rather than trusting the wattage.

Wattage is a starting guess, not a target. A 75 watt halogen is the usual starting point in a 4×2×2 ft enclosure; let the thermostat and the infrared thermometer settle it.

Heat that can't burn

- Keep every lamp at least 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) above the highest point the dragon can reach, behind a guard if it sits inside the enclosure. A lamp the dragon can touch will burn it at any setting.
- No basking surface needs to read above 122°F (50°C). Past that, the enclosure is overheating.
- Skip hot rocks and unguarded heat sources entirely. They are a common cause of thermal burns and add nothing a proper basking setup doesn't do better.
- At night, add heat only if the room drops below 65°F (18°C), and only with a source that gives no light.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Glass fogging or condensation	Humidity too high, or too little ventilation
Stays on the highest perch, rarely basks	Basking spot too cool, or too far away
Digs at the coolest corner, gapes, sits in the water	Enclosure too hot overall, no real cool side
Avoids the basking area, squints under the light	UVI too strong or bulb too close, or surface too hot

Thermostats, probes & timers

The thermostat is the safety device

A thermostat sits between the heat source and your dragon. It measures temperature at one point and cuts or lowers the power once that point reaches the setting, which stops a bulb that reads 105°F this morning from overshooting badly on a warm afternoon. Without one, a bulb draws full power with no ceiling at all.

HEAT SOURCE	CONTROLLER
Halogen or incandescent basking bulb	Dimming (proportional) thermostat. It turns the power down instead of switching the bulb off and on, which halogens hate and which makes the light flicker.
Ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector	Pulse proportional or dimming thermostat. Both heaters react fast enough that a plain on/off unit can overshoot before it cuts.
UVB tube	Never on a thermostat. It goes on a timer only.

Where the probe goes

Put the probe at the dragon's level on the basking platform; if your controller's manual gives another spot, follow the manual and still confirm the surface with the infrared thermometer. Hold it with a probe clip or suction cup, never tape, and never on the cool side. Tape over a probe throws off its reading, and a dragon can stick to exposed adhesive and tear scales. Set the thermostat so the infrared reading on the platform lands in the basking range. Never run any heat source unregulated.

How a thermostat fails

- **The probe moves.** This is the most common failure, and it is silent: the display keeps showing an accurate reading for the wrong spot. Check the probe's position at every spot clean.
- **The thermostat sticks on.** Rarer and more dangerous, because nothing limits the heat. Read the warm-end thermometer daily. The cool end always reads lower, and that gap is the gradient. A warm end that keeps climbing is the only warning of a stuck thermostat or a shifted probe.
- **Test it before the dragon arrives.** Run the setup for 24 to 48 hours and watch the thermostat dim the bulb as the probe warms.

Timers and the light schedule

Put every light on a plug-in timer so the day length never depends on you remembering. 12 to 14 hours of light in summer and 10 to 12 in winter matches the natural cycle, and the seasonal shift is often what cues brumation, the winter slowdown on page 25. All lights go off at night.

Night heat has no light

A light bulb cannot be used for night heat. If the room falls below 65°F (18°C) overnight, use a ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector on its own thermostat: both give heat with no visible light. Skip red, blue, and "moonlight" night bulbs entirely. A home that stays above 65°F at night needs no night heat at all.

UVB: tube, strength & mounting distance

This is the one piece of equipment worth spending real money on. UVB hitting the skin is how a dragon makes vitamin D3, and without vitamin D3 it cannot absorb calcium from its food. Use a linear T5 HO tube rated 10 to 14% UVB, each mounted to its own maker's distance chart; the distances below are for a 12% tube. Fit it in a reflector, spanning about two-thirds of the enclosure length on the basking side, never behind glass or plastic, which block UVB almost entirely. A mesh screen passes some UVB and filters the rest, so the mounting distance depends on whether a screen is in the way. Coil and compact bulbs are not adequate: they put UVB in one small spot instead of across the floor the dragon uses.

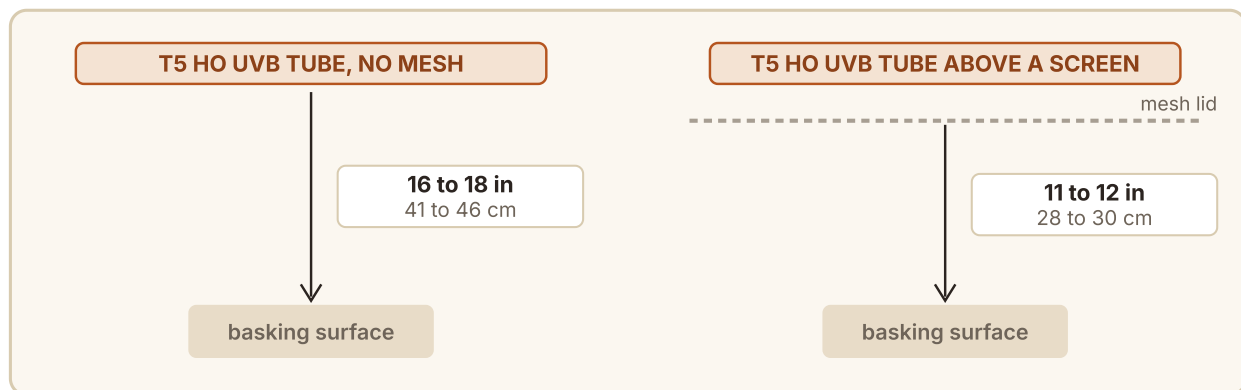
UVI targets

Bearded dragons are Ferguson Zone 3, open or partial-sun baskers. Aim for a gradient from 0 on the cool side up to **4.0 to 4.5** at the basking spot, or **3.0 or lower** for hypomelanistic, silkback and translucent morphs, which burn more easily. The dragon sets its own dose by moving between light and shade, so keep the cool end dim.

Bulb schedule

Run 10 to 14 hours a day on a timer. Replace every 6 to 12 months for T5 HO, every 6 months for a T8 (an older, weaker tube 1 inch across). Output fades long before the bulb dims, so replace by the calendar and write the date on page 44.

Mounting distance



Distances are for a 12% T5 HO tube in its reflector, with nothing in between on the left. A 10% or 14% tube varies by length and output, so follow its own distance chart.

Measure from the tube to the highest point the dragon can reach, not just the basking slab. Every perch, branch and hide top must sit at or below the chart's distance from the tube, or the dragon can climb into too much UVB.

UVB: meter & daylight lamp

MEASURE, DON'T ASSUME

A handheld UVI meter removes the guesswork. A UV index meter is the only way to know the tube is at the right height and when to replace it; UV cards show total UV, not the UVB that makes vitamin D3. It is the most expensive item in a reptile kit and highly recommended: read the UVI at the basking spot, adjust the height to 4.0 to 4.5, and re-check every three months.

The optional daylight lamp

A bright daylight LED (light-emitting diode) lamp, around 6500 K (kelvin, the scale for the color of light), alongside the UVB tube helps with activity and appetite. It gives white light only: no UVB and no basking heat.

Substrate, furnishings & bioactive setups

Substrate

Paper towel, newspaper, or slate or ceramic tile are the safest options, especially while you're new. Tile holds basking heat like rock, wipes clean and cannot be swallowed. A separate dig box (page 21) gives a dragon on tile somewhere to dig.

NEVER

Loose sand (including calcium sand), crushed walnut shell, wood chips, or gravel. All carry a real impaction risk if ingested, whatever the label says (page 29).

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Basking platform (rock, slate, or sturdy wood) directly under the lamp
- ☐ Two hides: one warm side, one cool side
- ☐ Sturdy, well-anchored climbing branches at more than one height
- ☐ Shallow water dish the dragon can climb out of easily
- ☐ Food dish or slate for greens, wiped daily
- ☐ Dig box, and a deeper lay box for adult females (page 23)

Bioactive setups

A bioactive enclosure is planted, with a living substrate and a cleanup crew of isopods and springtails, tiny invertebrates that break down waste. It gives a dragon somewhere to dig and explore and cuts full substrate changes to almost none once the crew is established. It is a bigger commitment than paper towel and not where most people should start, and it changes the floor and the cleaning, nothing else: the heat, UVB and diet stay exactly the same.

PART	WHAT IT TAKES
Substrate	A pre-formulated arid bioactive substrate, 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) deep across the floor, topped with dry leaf litter. Deep enough for roots, digging, and a slightly damp bottom layer under a dry surface. A homemade sand, topsoil and clay mix makes a good loose substrate but is not bioactive-ready on its own. Use organic topsoil with no fertilizer if you mix your own.
Cleanup crew	Arid species: powder orange or powder blue isopods, dwarf white isopods, and arid springtails. Seed them in the damp lower layer and give them a few weeks to a month to multiply before the dragon goes in.
Plants	A dragon eats its plants, so every one must be safe to eat, free of pesticide, and able to take a desert basking lamp: succulents, spineless cacti, arid grasses. Rinse nursery plants first. Skip pothos, a poor pick for a grazing lizard. Keep plants out of the basking zone so they don't shade the dragon from the tube.
Upkeep	Water plant bases or mist lightly and let the surface dry; over-misting turns an arid build into a swamp. Pick up visible waste daily and let the crew handle the rest. No monthly strip-down. Top up leaf litter about once a year. Run well, the substrate can go 10 years or more.

Cleaning & hygiene

Cleaning removes the waste. Disinfecting kills what is left. Hygiene keeps it off your hands.

SALMONELLA

Healthy reptiles shed *Salmonella* bacteria in their droppings without being ill, on and off, and one negative test clears nothing. It travels from the dragon, its enclosure and anything it walks on to hands, then to mouths or food, so wash with soap and running water after every contact. Do not kiss the dragon, hold it to your face, or eat or drink while holding it. Children under 5, adults 65 and older and anyone with a weakened immune system should not handle the dragon or touch anything in its enclosure. Pregnant people are also at higher risk. An outbreak traced to pet bearded dragons, closed in December 2025, made 20 people sick across 14 states, put 9 in the hospital and killed 1.

Three clocks

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Daily	Remove droppings, urates (the white part of the waste), uneaten food and shed skin as soon as you see them. Empty, wash and refill the water dish. Wipe the food dish.
Weekly	Wipe down glass, walls, dishes, decor and the basking platform with a reptile-safe cleaner.
Monthly	Move the dragon to a secure temporary tub. Take everything out, scrub it with detergent and hot water, disinfect the enclosure, decor and dishes, rinse, dry, and put in fresh substrate.

Paper towel or newspaper is replaced whenever it is soiled. A bioactive enclosure skips the monthly strip-down: pick up what you can see and let the cleanup crew handle the rest.

Disinfecting, step by step

- **Scrub first.** A film of waste shields bacteria from disinfectant, so it only works on a surface already cleaned.
- **Dilute household bleach 1:32**, which is half a cup of bleach per gallon of water. It is inexpensive and works against bacteria and many viruses.
- **Keep it wet for 10 minutes.** Bleach needs that long in contact to work, so don't wipe it straight off.
- **Rinse until no bleach smell remains**, then let the enclosure and every item dry completely and air out before the dragon goes back in. Plan on a full day of airing.

NEVER THE KITCHEN SINK

Never wash the dragon, its dishes, decor or enclosure in a kitchen sink, a bathroom sink, or a bath people use, or anywhere food is prepared. Keep a plastic tub for the job, or work in a utility sink or outdoors. If a bathtub does get used, clean it thoroughly afterward. Wash bedding and decor separately from anything used for food, and keep the dragon out of the kitchen entirely.

If someone in the house gets sick

The signs are ordinary ones: diarrhea, fever, stomach cramps. That is why the link gets missed. Tell the doctor there is a reptile in the house, even if nobody remembers touching it, since enclosure surfaces are enough on their own. It matters most for a child under 5, an adult 65 or older, someone pregnant, or someone with a weakened immune system, in whom the infection can spread beyond the gut.

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet by age

Bearded dragons are omnivores, and the ratio flips with age: juveniles eat mostly insects, adults mostly plants. This mirrors a real dietary shift documented in wild dragons, not an arbitrary husbandry rule. Only feed when the basking surface is at temperature. A dragon needs that heat to make stomach acid and digestive enzymes, so a dragon that can't bask can't digest.

AGE	INSECTS TO GREENS	HOW OFTEN	HOW MUCH
Hatchling (under about 1 month)	Mostly insects	2 to 3× daily, mostly flightless fruit flies and gut-loaded pinhead crickets	As many small insects as it eats in 10 to 15 minutes. Fresh greens available every day even if ignored.
1 to 4 months	About 80% insects, 20% greens	Twice daily, insects plus vegetables	The same 10 to 15 minute rule.
Juvenile (4 to 18 months)	About 80% insects, 20% greens, moving toward greens as growth slows	Insects once daily; a fresh salad every day, every other day at minimum	The same rule. Most juveniles ignore salad until about 6 months; keep offering it so the habit is there once insects taper off.
Adult (18 months and up)	About 20% insects, 80% greens	Greens daily; insects a few times a week	The insect portion is set by body condition (page 18). Salad daily, a pile about the size of the head.

DON'T FEED AN ADULT LIKE A JUVENILE

Growth has stopped and metabolism has slowed by 18 months. An adult still eating a juvenile's insect ration gets fat, and fatty liver disease is the long-term risk. Fatty feeders such as waxworms and superworms as a daily food are the usual culprits.

Why a dragon stops eating

Most refusals are normal. Work through the list before assuming illness:

Brumation	The winter slowdown in dragons over a year old (page 25)	Too cool	A cold basking spot slows or stalls digestion
Shedding	A short appetite drop around the shed	Illness or impaction	With other signs: lethargy, abnormal or no stool, straining, a swollen belly
A gravid female	Eggs, with or without a male: off food 1 to 2 weeks before laying (page 23)	A picky phase	Bored with one food. Rule it out before assuming the worst
Stress	A new home, a small enclosure, another dragon, too much handling		

WHEN IT IS A VET CALL

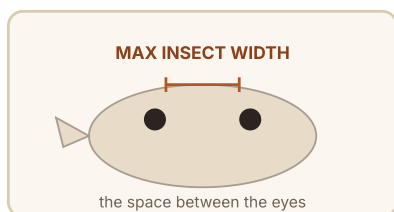
A juvenile off food for 2 to 3 days, since it has far less room to wait. An adult off food for 1 to 2 weeks outside brumation. Any refusal at any age that comes with lethargy, abnormal stool or a swollen belly.

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Feeder insects & gut-loading

Captive-bred only, gut-loaded, and no wider than the space between the eyes.

INSECT	TIER	NOTES
Dubia roaches	STAPLE	The best all-round feeder: good protein, low fat, easy to gut-load, quiet, no smell, and they can't climb smooth plastic.
Black soldier fly larvae	STAPLE	Naturally calcium-rich, soft and small, ideal for hatchlings and juveniles. Keep the calcium schedule anyway.
Crickets	STAPLE	Cheap and active, which triggers hunting. Gut-load well and remove any left at lights-out; loose crickets nibble a sleeping dragon.
Silkworms	STAPLE	Soft, high moisture, low fat and readily eaten. Pricier and short-lived, so buy small batches.
Locusts / grasshoppers (captive-bred)	STAPLE	Common in the United Kingdom and Europe. Excellent nutrition and a strong hunting response. Never wild-caught.
Hornworms	OCCASIONAL	Mostly water: great for hydration or tempting a dragon off food, poor as a staple. They grow fast, so re-check the size daily.
Earthworms (pesticide-free source, not bait shop)	OCCASIONAL	Safe now and then; many dragons ignore them.
Mealworms	OCCASIONAL	Hard shell and fatty. Adults only, a few at a time, never for juveniles.
Superworms	OCCASIONAL	Fatty and they bite. Adults only, tong-fed, never left loose in the enclosure.
Waxworms	TREAT ONLY	Very high fat and habit-forming. A few per week at most, none for an overweight dragon.
Butterworms	TREAT ONLY	Fatty but calcium-rich. Same limits as waxworms.
Freeze-dried or canned insects	TOPPER ONLY	Little nutrition and no moisture. Fine sprinkled on salad, never the insect ration.
Fireflies (lightning bugs)	NEVER	Contain lucibufagin toxins. A single firefly can kill a bearded dragon.
Wild-caught insects, spiders, centipedes	NEVER	Pesticide and parasite risk, and some are venomous or toxic.
Ladybugs, boxelder bugs, stink bugs, monarch caterpillars	NEVER	Toxic or foul-tasting. Not worth the gamble even from a garden you don't spray.



Sizing and storage

Prey wider than the gap between the eyes is a choking and impaction risk, and in juveniles it can cause hind-leg weakness. When in doubt, go smaller and feed more. Keep feeders in a ventilated tub with room to move, since crowded crickets die fast, and never feed an insect that smells off or came from a tub with dead ones in it.

Gut-loading: feed the feeders

An insect is a container: what it ate last is what your dragon gets. Feed feeders a calcium-rich diet for 24 to 72 hours before they go in, 48 hours being the usual figure: collard, mustard, turnip or dandelion greens, butternut squash, or a dry commercial gut-load sold on its calcium content. Carrot, potato and apple keep insects alive but add almost no calcium, and spinach, beet greens and Swiss chard work against it. Insects empty their gut once off the food, so feed them out within a few hours. Gut-loading does not replace dusting (page 17).

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Safe greens & vegetables

Staples have more calcium than phosphorus and little oxalate. Build the salad from them; add variety from the lower tiers.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Collard greens	STAPLE	Backbone green: very high calcium, low oxalate, cheap all year.
Mustard greens	STAPLE	High calcium, peppery, well accepted. Rotate with collards.
Turnip greens	STAPLE	Same class as collards. Leaves only; the root is occasional.
Dandelion greens and flowers	STAPLE	Excellent calcium. Store-bought, or from ground never sprayed.
Endive and escarole	STAPLE	Mild, good calcium, often the first green a picky dragon takes.
Watercress, arugula (rocket)	STAPLE	Strong flavor, good nutrition. Fine in the rotation.
Cactus pad (nopál), spines removed	STAPLE	High calcium and hydrating. Sold in many grocery stores.
Winter squash (butternut, acorn), raw and grated	STAPLE	The staple vegetable. Grate finely; no need to cook.
Green beans, snap peas	STAPLE	Chop small. Good texture variety.
Bell pepper, okra, yellow summer squash	STAPLE	Small amounts. Good vitamins; a few pieces mixed in, not the salad base.
Kale, bok choy, cabbage, broccoli	OCCASIONAL	Goitrogens. A couple of times a week in rotation, never daily.
Carrot, sweet potato (raw, grated)	OCCASIONAL	High in vitamin A. A pinch for color and variety.
Zucchini, cucumber, romaine, celery	OCCASIONAL	Mostly water. Fine for hydration, useless as a staple.
Cilantro, basil, parsley, mint	OCCASIONAL	Scent tempts picky eaters. Parsley is high oxalate, keep it small.
Tomato, peas, corn, asparagus	RARE	Acidic or phosphorus-heavy. A few pieces now and then.
Spinach, Swiss chard, beet greens	RARE	High oxalate binds calcium. Not toxic, but never a regular food.
Iceberg lettuce	SKIP	Just water. Causes runny stool and teaches dragons to ignore greens.
Avocado, rhubarb, onion, garlic, leek, chives	NEVER	Avoid. Avocado's persin is toxic in birds and many mammals, with no known safe amount for reptiles, and rhubarb's oxalic acid binds calcium.
Raw potato, nightshade leaves, mushrooms	NEVER	Nightshade toxins, or no benefit and real risk.

Wash, chop to bite size, and replace the salad daily rather than leaving it to wilt. If greens are refused, offer them before insects in the morning with a little grated squash or a berry mixed in. Juveniles often ignore salad until about 6 months; keep offering it.

Why the tiers exist. Oxalates, in spinach, chard, beet greens and parsley, bind calcium in the gut so the dragon can't absorb it, even from a food that is calcium-rich on paper. Goitrogens, in kale, cabbage and broccoli, can interfere with the thyroid in large, regular amounts. Staples dodge both.

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Fruit, treats & the never-feed list

Fruit is a treat: about 5 to 10 percent of the plant portion, once or twice a week at most.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Figs, papaya, prickly pear fruit	OCCASIONAL	The best fruits: better calcium balance than most. Still a treat.
Berries: strawberry, blueberry, raspberry, blackberry	OCCASIONAL	Chop small. A good "hide the medicine" or picky-eater food.
Mango, melon, apple and pear (cored), peach, apricot, plum (no pit)	OCCASIONAL	Sugary and mostly water. A few small pieces mixed into greens.
Banana, grapes (halved), kiwi	RARE	High phosphorus or sugar. A tiny amount, rarely.
Citrus: orange, lemon, lime, grapefruit, pineapple	NEVER	Acidic; causes stomach upset and diarrhea.
Dried fruit, fruit pits and seeds, canned fruit in syrup	NEVER	Concentrated sugar, choking risk, or cyanide-containing seeds.

Extras and "human food" questions

ITEM	VERDICT	NOTES
Commercial pellets or salad toppers	OCCASIONAL	Fine sprinkled on greens for variety, never the main diet.
Bee pollen	OCCASIONAL	A pinch on salad as an appetite booster. Optional.
Pinky mice	RARE	Not a routine food. Occasionally for a larger adult female, usually during a laying cycle, and only when a reptile vet suggests it for a specific reason.
Eggs, meat, chicken, fish	NEVER	Wrong protein and fat balance for this species.
Dog, cat, or rabbit food	NEVER	Nutritionally wrong for this species and hard on the kidneys.
Bread, pasta, dairy, chips, anything processed	NEVER	No benefit. Reptiles can't digest lactose at all.

THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado · rhubarb · onion, garlic, leek, chives · citrus · raw potato, nightshade leaves and stems · mushrooms · fireflies · any wild-caught insect · ladybugs, boxelder bugs, stink bugs, monarch caterpillars · any insect wider than the space between the eyes · eggs, meat, dairy, pet food, processed food · anything sprayed with pesticide. Houseplants count during free-roam: pothos, philodendron, ivy, lilies, daffodils, and oleander are all toxic.

BUILDING THE DAILY SALAD

Two or three staple greens chopped fine (collards, mustard greens and dandelion greens is a reliable rotation), one staple vegetable grated on top, and a pinch from the occasional tier. Rotate the greens week to week so no single one is the whole salad, and on a calcium day with no insect feeding, dust the salad instead.

Supplements: calcium, vitamin D3 & multivitamin

The supplement schedule and the UVB distance are the two things a dragon's bones depend on.

SUPPLEMENT	HATCHLING & JUVENILE	ADULT	NOTES
Plain calcium (no vitamin D3, phosphorus-free)	Near-daily, at most feedings	2 to 3× per week	The everyday dust. Light coating, not a snowball.
Calcium with D3	Replaces plain calcium 2× per week	2× per week	A backup to UVB, not a substitute.
Multivitamin (reptile-specific)	1 to 2× per week	1 to 2× per week	Skip the D3 calcium that day if the multivitamin already contains D3.

WHY NOT D3 AT EVERY FEEDING

Under a correct T5 HO tube the dragon makes its own vitamin D3. Adding supplemental D3 at every feeding on top of that risks vitamin D toxicity, which calcifies soft tissue and is far harder to treat than a calcium shortfall. Plain calcium is the daily dust; the D3 version is insurance.

Why the tube beats the powder

This has been tested directly. Oonincx and colleagues (2010) raised 84 hatchling bearded dragons either on rising doses of oral vitamin D3, up to four times the standard dose, or under UVB for 2 to 12 hours a day. At six months, the dragons under UVB had blood levels of the main circulating form of vitamin D3 18 times higher than the supplemented dragons, and as little as 2 hours of UVB a day kept those levels adequate. No dose of powder came close. That is why D3 in the dust is a backup and never the plan.

Dusting and gut-loading are two jobs

Feeder insects are a poor calcium source on their own. A dragon needs more calcium than phosphorus in its diet, roughly 2 parts to 1, and analyses by Finke put unsupplemented crickets near 1 part calcium to 9 of phosphorus and mealworms near 1 to 14. Black soldier fly larvae are the one common feeder close to or above 1 to 1. Gut-loading improves what is inside the insect; the powder adds calcium on the outside. Neither replaces the other, and neither counts for much without working UVB.

- **Dust right before feeding.** Powder falls off, and an insect left dusted for an hour has groomed much of it away.
- **Read the label.** The daily dust is a plain calcium carbonate powder with no added vitamins. Keep a D3 formula for the twice-weekly slot only.
- **Date the jars.** Replace opened powders by the date on the jar, and log the date on page 44.

FEMALES NEED MORE DURING A LAYING CYCLE

Making eggs, even infertile ones, pulls calcium from her bones. Correct UVB and the schedule above cover most of it. Ask your vet about a temporary increase during an active cycle rather than guessing at a dose, and after she lays, dust her food with plain calcium daily for about two weeks (page 23).

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Growth, weight & body condition

The scale and the tail base say whether the feeding schedule is working.

Growth reference

Ranges are deliberately wide and healthy dragons fall outside them. What matters is the trend: steady gain for a juvenile, a stable weight for an adult.

AGE	TOTAL LENGTH	WEIGHT
Hatchling (0 to 1 month)	3 to 4 in (8 to 10 cm)	under 10 g
2 months	5 to 9 in (13 to 23 cm)	10 to 40 g
3 to 4 months	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm)	30 to 90 g
5 to 6 months	11 to 16 in (28 to 41 cm)	80 to 200 g
8 to 10 months	13 to 20 in (33 to 51 cm)	150 to 350 g
12 months	16 to 22 in (41 to 56 cm)	250 to 450 g
18 months and up (adult)	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm)	300 to 500 g typical; large males heavier

The weekly weigh-in

- Weigh at the same time of day, ideally before the first feeding, so a full stomach doesn't skew the reading.
- Use a kitchen or postal scale that reads to single grams, and write every reading down on page 43.
- Watch the line, not the number. A juvenile's climbs, with the odd flat or slightly lower week around a shed. An adult's stays roughly flat, apart from a dip around a shed or a laying cycle.

Body condition at a glance

UNDERWEIGHT

Hip bones and spine visible, tail base thin and triangular instead of round, the fat pads on top of the head sunken into hollows, eyes sunken. Skin wrinkles when the dragon isn't shedding. Rule out parasites and a basking spot that is too cool first, then feed up under vet guidance.

IDEAL

Tail base full and rounded, head fat pads level with the skull, belly flat and off the ground when standing, a defined waist from above. Weight stable week to week in an adult, climbing steadily in a juvenile.

OVERWEIGHT

Bulging fat pads on the head, jowls under the jaw, rolls at the armpits, a tail base thicker than the thighs, belly dragging. Common in adults fed like juveniles. Cut fatty feeders, shift toward salad, add climbing and free-roam. Fatty liver disease is the long-term risk.

The tail base is the most reliable place to look: under- and overweight dragons both show it first. A dragon from smaller stock that has always tracked the low end of its age bracket is not a problem to fix; that is its normal.

WHEN A WEIGHT CHANGE IS A VET VISIT

A juvenile that stops gaining for 3 to 4 weeks. An adult that loses about 10 percent of its body weight outside brumation, or any weight loss that comes with appetite loss, lethargy, or abnormal stool. Bring the weight log; a trend line tells a vet more than a single reading.

Handling & taming

One of the most handleable pet lizards there is, once it has had time to settle.

Wait before the first session

Give a new dragon 7 to 14 days to settle before handling it beyond feeding and cleaning. It needs time to learn where the food and the basking spot are, and that its new home isn't a threat. That settling clock is separate from quarantine, which runs far longer: if another reptile already lives in the house, handling can start after two weeks but always comes last in the day, after the resident animals, with hands washed in between.

DAYS	WHAT TO DO
1 to 3	Hands off, except feeding and spot-cleaning.
4 to 7	Calm presence near the enclosure, a hand resting inside at feeding time.
7 to 14	First short handling sessions once appetite and stool look normal. Shorter and more frequent for juveniles, which are more fragile.

How to pick one up

Let the dragon see your hand coming, from the side or below, never from above, which reads as a predator strike. Never surprise or grab it. Scoop from underneath with both hands, supporting the chest, belly and all four legs so nothing dangles, and don't squeeze to hold it still: squeezing sets off an escape attempt rather than calming one. Never pick up or lift a bearded dragon by the tail.

How often and how long

Once it is settled and eating normally, a short session every day builds trust faster than occasional long ones. Start short and build up to about 10 to 15 minutes. Heat sets the ceiling: out of the enclosure too long, a dragon's body temperature drops, so a cooler room means a shorter session.

- Let it bask after a meal before a handling session; it needs the heat to digest.
- Handle low, over a bed or couch, not standing. A dragon will launch off a hand without warning, and a fall that looks minor can cause a serious injury.
- Mid-shed, let the skin come off on its own.

PUT IT DOWN WHEN YOU SEE

A beard turning dark or black · skin darkening along the back and sides · backing away from your hand, or threatening to bite · struggling to get free · flattening, gaping or hissing. None is dangerous on its own, but each one means the session is over. End it calmly.

Who should hold it

A bearded dragon suits older children, with an adult supervising. Children under 5 should not handle one at all, and neither should adults 65 and older or anyone with a weakened immune system, because a healthy-looking dragon can still carry *Salmonella* (page 12). Wash hands with soap after every session, even a short one. Handled correctly and consistently, most bearded dragons become easygoing, and some seek out time on a shoulder or in a lap.

Body language: beard, color, arm-wave & glass surfing

What a dragon is telling you, and which signals are a job for you or a vet.

YOU SEE	IT USUALLY MEANS	DO
Beard puffed out and darkened	Stress, a threat, a territorial display, or breeding. Normal for a few hours during a shed or a stressful moment	Find the trigger. Vet if it stays dark for days, especially with lethargy or appetite loss
Back darker when cool, paler once warm	Temperature control: dark skin absorbs heat faster. For wild dragons, Smith and colleagues (2016) put the saving at about 22 minutes of basking per active day	Nothing. The beard and chest change color for social reasons instead
Skin darkening along the back and sides while held	Stress	End the handling session
Arm-wave: a slow, circular roll of one front leg	Most likely submission to a more dominant animal, easy to misread as a friendly hello	Nothing. Note what it can see: a reflection or another pet
Flattening, gaping or hissing at a hand	Defensive: it wants you to stop	Back off and try again later
Gaping while basking, otherwise normal	Normal temperature control	Nothing, unless it comes with wheezing or mucus
Mouth open at rest, with wheezing, clicking or mucus	Respiratory infection	Vet promptly (page 30)
Digging at the coolest corner, gaping, sitting in the water	The enclosure is too hot overall	Re-measure the gradient and give it a real cool side
Head held tilted up and back	"Stargazing," a sign of brain or nerve disease	An emergency, not a behavior
Eating less, hiding more, sleeping earlier over weeks in fall	Possible brumation, the winter slowdown	Vet check first, then let it happen (page 25)
Female digging, pacing, restless in the afternoon	Gravid: carrying eggs, with or without a male	Lay box on the warm side now (page 23)

Glass surfing

Repetitive pacing or scratching along the glass. Work through the usual causes in order: a reflection or another pet in view; an enclosure that's too small, or too hot with no real cool side; boredom or hunger; and, in an adult female, a gravid dragon looking for somewhere to lay. Cover reflective surfaces on three sides and reduce disruptive activity near the enclosure before assuming it's just "personality." Enrichment helps only once the enclosure itself is right; fixing the underlying trigger resolves it faster than covering glass alone.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

Brumation is slow and low-energy. Glass surfing is repetitive and high-energy. If you're not sure which you're seeing, the energy level is usually the tell.

Enrichment & common mistakes

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Undersizing the enclosure "because it's just a baby," then never upgrading once it's an adult.
- Buying a UVB bulb once and never tracking its replacement date, or running a coil bulb and assuming it counts.
- Running a basking bulb with no thermostat, or putting the probe on the cool side where it never triggers.
- Skipping the cool side entirely, leaving no way for the dragon to cool down.
- Dusting calcium with D3 at every feeding on top of strong UVB, or skipping calcium entirely because "the UVB handles it."
- Feeding an adult like a juvenile, leading to obesity and fatty liver over time.
- Trusting packaging that says "reptile safe" without checking it for this species. Loose sand is the classic example.
- Skipping quarantine when introducing a new reptile, or sharing tools and feeder tubs between animals.
- Estimating UVI by eye. Output can look bright while being too weak, or too strong for a sensitive morph.

Enrichment, by priority

Enrichment comes after correct heat, UVB, diet, hydration and enclosure size, never instead of them. In this order:

1. Climbing structure

Sturdy branches, cork and ledges at varied heights let a dragon survey from above and choose its own distance from the heat. Rough textures help grip and wear the nails. Anchor everything; unstable stacked rocks are a crush-injury risk.

2. Dig box

A tub the dragon can turn around in, filled 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) deep with a 50/50 mix of organic topsoil and washed play sand, kept slightly damp. Never calcium sand. Adult females need a deeper version (page 23).

3. Visual security

Partial barriers, plants, or a half-covered side let a dragon retreat from view without leaving the warm zone, which lowers baseline stress in busy rooms.

4. Foraging and hunting

Tong-feeding, short supervised insect hunts, scattered or hung greens, and a rolling treat ball the dragon nudges until insects fall out. Remove uneaten insects before lights-out.

5. Supervised free-roam

10 to 15 minutes to start, building toward 15 to 30 for some adults, in a warm, draft-free room with gaps blocked, other pets out, and cords, toxic plants and anything small enough to swallow removed. End it if the dragon cools, panics, blackens its beard or turns lethargic. Never unsupervised. Outdoor time is optional and more advanced: supervised, in a secure pen, with shade and water.

6. Novelty rotation

Reposition one furnishing every few weeks. Constant rearranging is stressful; a recognizable layout with one new thing is the sweet spot.

Choosing a dragon, quarantine & the first vet visit

Young, captive-bred, checked over in good light, and in front of a vet within 48 hours.

A young, captive-raised dragon makes the better pet. A breeder who hatched it can tell you its hatch date, its food, and when it last ate and shed. Buy only where the enclosures are clean and large enough. A rescue or an expo animal often comes with no reliable history: not a reason to refuse it, but a reason to run the full quarantine below.

Look before you pay

CHECK	HEALTHY	WALK AWAY OR ASK MORE
Alertness	Active, head up and watching you, a strong grip	Limp, unresponsive, or unable to hold on
Tail base	Round and plump just behind the back legs	Thin tail base, loose skin, a skinny body, visible hips or spine
Eyes	Bright, open and clear	Sunken, swollen, crusted, or cloudy
Mouth	Bright pink, clear saliva	Cloudy mucus, cottage-cheese material, red or bruised gums
Nose, breathing	Dry nostrils, quiet breathing	Bubbles, mucus, wheezing, open-mouth breathing
Vent (the opening under the tail)	Clean	Stained, pasted with droppings, or swollen
Skin	Intact, no old shed left on	Wounds, or rings of old shed on toes and tail tip

Ask the seller: the hatch date; whether it was captive-bred; what it eats and when it last ate; whether it has been treated for anything; and whether it comes with a health guarantee. A good breeder answers without looking anything up.

Quarantine: 3 to 6 months

If another reptile already lives in the house, keep the new dragon completely apart for 3 to 6 months. 60 to 90 days is a floor, not a target: some infections show nothing for months. With no other reptile, skip the separation but not the vet visit.

- **A separate room.** Two enclosures on one shelf share the same air.
- **Paper towel, a hide and a water dish.** Paper shows stool and regurgitated food at a glance.
- **Separate tools, and the new dragon last.** Its own tongs, dishes and feeder tub, cared for after every other animal, with hands washed in between.
- **Restart the clock** if anything flags: a positive fecal test, a regurgitated meal, unexplained weight loss. At the end, disinfect everything that touched it.

THE FIRST VET VISIT, WITHIN 48 HOURS

Book a reptile vet before the dragon comes home (finding one is on page 27). The first exam should include a weight, a look inside the mouth, eyes and nostrils, a skin and skeleton check, and a fecal test, so bring a fresh stool sample under 24 hours old in a sealed bag. Ask about a PCR (polymerase chain reaction) swab, the test for ADV (atadenovirus), before this dragon ever meets another. That visit is the baseline every later one is measured against.

Sexing & females that lay

Every female owner needs this page, whether or not a male has ever been in the house.

Telling male from female

Reliable from about 4 to 6 months; under 3 months it is very difficult, so treat pet-store sexing of a hatchling as a guess and recheck at 6 months. In a dim room, gently lift the tail to about 90 degrees and shine a phone flashlight down through the base of the tail from above. **Males** show two hemipenal bulges, one either side of a central dip, just past the vent. **Females** show a single central bulge or nothing at all. Adult males also have larger femoral pores (a row of waxy pores along the underside of the thighs), a bigger head and a darker beard display, but none of these is reliable on its own in a young dragon.

Females lay without a male

From roughly one to two years old, many females develop egg follicles and lay infertile clutches, typically 15 to 30 eggs, sometimes two or three clutches in a season. Some never do. Neither is a problem by itself. What matters is recognizing it and giving her somewhere to dig.

Signs she is gravid

- A big appetite for a few weeks, then going off food in the one to two weeks before laying.
- Restlessness: digging at corners, glass surfing, pacing the enclosure, especially in the afternoon.
- A rounder belly that feels like a bag of marbles when she walks. Never squeeze to check; eggs bruise easily.

The lay box

A container she can turn around in, bigger rather than smaller, filled 6 to 12 in (15 to 30 cm) deep with a 50/50 mix of organic topsoil and washed play sand, damp enough that a tunnel holds its shape without dripping. Too dry and her tunnels collapse; too wet risks mold. Put it on the warm side as soon as you see the signs and leave it until she's done. She may dig several test holes over a few days, then lay in one sitting and fill it in.

AFTER SHE LAYS

Remove the infertile eggs. She'll be thin and hungry: feed her well, dust her food with plain calcium daily for about two weeks, and offer a soak. A female that cycles constantly, several times a year, every year, is worth a vet conversation about long-term options, including spaying.

Egg binding

Dystocia: a female who cannot pass the eggs she is carrying. A same-day emergency.

Egg binding is common in reptiles and can be life-threatening. A normal gravid female and one in trouble look alike at first, since both stop eating. The line is clear once you know it: a normal gravid female stays bright, active and alert; a female with egg binding quickly becomes sick, weak, or unresponsive.

SIGN	NORMAL GRAVID FEMALE	EGG BINDING
Appetite	Reduced or absent in the 1 to 2 weeks before laying	Absent, and doesn't return
Activity	Bright, active, alert despite not eating	Lethargic, weak, or unresponsive
Digging	Test digs over a few days, then lays and fills the hole	Straining and digging for 24 to 48 hours or more with no eggs
Eyes	Normal	Sunken
Body	Rounder belly, normal muscle tone	Weakness, especially in the hind legs; may refuse water
Over days	Moves toward laying, then eating again	No progress, or getting worse

CALL A REPTILE VET THE SAME DAY IF

She has been digging and straining for more than 24 to 48 hours with no eggs, or laid part of a clutch and then stopped and looks exhausted · she shows lethargy, sunken eyes, hind-leg weakness, refuses water, or has a firm lump in the belly that doesn't shift over several days · she is past the normal "off food" stage but losing condition instead of moving toward laying.

What causes it

- **Husbandry:** wrong UVB, wrong temperatures, low humidity, or no suitable place to lay.
- **Her body:** obesity, poor muscle tone from too little activity, and age.
- **The eggs:** oversized or malformed eggs, or something blocking the passage.
- **Nutrition and illness:** too little calcium or protein, dehydration, infection, constipation, or an abscess or mass.

What the vet does

A vet confirms it with an exam, gentle feeling of the belly, blood work and X-rays, sometimes ultrasound. Unlike in mammals, a reptile can hold eggs for weeks or months past the normal window, which makes the urgency easy to misjudge; it is a reason to get a diagnosis, never a reason to wait at home. With no blockage, treatment can mean fluids, calcium, and a hormone injection to start laying. With a blockage, inducing her is unsafe and surgery is needed, usually removing the egg-carrying organs so the problem cannot recur. A related condition, follicles that never ovulate, shows up as masses on imaging and goes down the same route. The longer it waits, the fewer options remain. A lay box that is always available to an adult female is the cheapest prevention there is.

Brumation

A seasonal slowdown, not a medical crisis, once a vet has ruled illness out.

Brumation is a reptile's winter slowdown, cued by shorter days and cooler nights. It is not true hibernation: a brumating dragon stays somewhat responsive and still gets up now and then to drink. It is most common in dragons over a year old; a hatchling or young juvenile that goes quiet and stops eating is far more likely to be sick than seasonal.

Signs, over several weeks: eating less, then not at all · more time in a hide, away from the basking spot · sleeping earlier and getting up later · less activity and interest in handling · a darker beard or body in some dragons · little or no stool. Adults often pass only urate, with no solid stool, for days at a time.

BRUMATION OR ILLNESS?

The same signs describe a sick dragon: low temperatures, parasites, dehydration and poor nutrition all look like this. Brumation develops slowly, over weeks, in a dragon over a year old, as the days shorten. A dragon going downhill quickly, at a normal room temperature, out of season, or under a year old is a vet visit, not a waiting game.

The pre-brumation vet check

Before letting a slowdown run, have a reptile vet do an exam and a fecal test, so the dragon goes in healthy rather than already sick or carrying parasites; one that goes in thin or with a parasite load can come out far worse. Once it is cleared, don't force-feed it, and don't try to stop brumation in a healthy adult.

The weekly routine

Weigh it	Every week, in grams, to catch weight loss long before it shows.
Offer a soak	Shallow and lukewarm, about 15 minutes, chest-deep at most, never unsupervised. Most ignore it; some drink.
Greens, no insects	Fresh greens every few days. No insects: a dragon that isn't basking can't digest them.
Shorten the light	8 to 10 hours on the timer, or lights off if it is fully asleep in its hide and not coming out to bask.
Hold the floor	Keep the room above 65°F (18°C), checked on a thermometer, with a ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector on its own thermostat if it drops below overnight.

Brumation typically runs 1 to 3 months. Resume the full schedule the day the dragon reappears and basks on its own. Appetite usually returns within 2 to 3 weeks: offer small amounts at first, gut-loaded and dusted from the first meal back.

CALL THE VET IF

It stretches past about three and a half months · weight drops more than about 10 percent · appetite hasn't returned within 2 to 3 weeks of waking · sunken eyes, thick or stringy saliva, diarrhea, foul or bloody stool · limb swelling, tremors, or trouble lifting the body · any of this under a year old, or a slowdown at a normal 60 to 70°F (16 to 21°C) room temperature with no seasonal change in the light.

Is a bearded dragon legal where you live?

Legal without a permit almost everywhere in the United States, with a short list of exceptions.

This page covers all 50 states, the District of Columbia and New York City, which has its own rules: 52 jurisdictions. A pet bearded dragon is **legal with no permit in 46**, **barred in 2**, **permit-only in 2**, and **legal on a condition in 2**.

WHERE	STATUS	THE RULE
Hawaii	Barred	Named on the Restricted Animal List, Part A (Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6.5), which is for research and exhibition only. No route for a household.
District of Columbia	Barred	District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j)(1) bars keeping wildlife except seven listed groups. The reptile group is non-venomous snakes, fish and turtles; no lizard appears.
New Jersey	Permit	Any exotic species needs a permit unless named as exempt (New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4.2(a) and 4.4). The bearded dragon is not, so it needs the individual hobby permit.
West Virginia	Permit	West Virginia Code § 20-2-13 bars bringing in or keeping live wildlife from out of state without an importation permit from the director, captive-bred or not. No application is published: ask the state in writing before the dragon crosses the line, and keep the reply.
Maine	Conditional	Named by species on the Unrestricted Species List, under the heading "Captive Bred Origin Only." Close to a formality for this species, since captive-bred is the only kind there is.
Minnesota	Conditional	Minnesota Statutes § 97A.401, subdivision 8: a lizard from a permitted breeder, or held before 1 August 2021, may be kept as a pet. The breeder permit is not visibly in place yet, so ask the state wildlife agency how to meet the condition.

Legal with no permit: 46 jurisdictions

Alabama, Alaska, Arizona, Arkansas, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, Florida, Georgia, Idaho, Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maryland, Massachusetts, Michigan, Mississippi, Missouri, Montana, Nebraska, Nevada, New Hampshire, New Mexico, New York State, New York City, North Carolina, North Dakota, Ohio, Oklahoma, Oregon, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, South Carolina, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Vermont, Virginia, Washington, Wisconsin and Wyoming.

In eight of them, Colorado, Illinois, Maryland, Michigan, Montana, Nevada, Oregon and Washington, the state lets cities or counties be stricter, so check your local ordinance (a city or county law) too. Bringing a dragon into Michigan calls for a certificate of veterinary inspection.

WHY EVERY DRAGON HERE IS CAPTIVE-BRED

Australia banned the commercial export of all live native vertebrates in 1982, under the Wildlife Protection (Regulation of Exports and Imports) Act, and the ban carried into the Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999. The trade outside Australia is entirely captive-bred, with no lawful wild-caught supply.

NOT LEGAL ADVICE

State legal status as of October 2026. This is a summary of state rules, read on 1 October 2026 (Maine on 5 September 2026), and not legal advice. Rules change. Before you buy or move, check with your state wildlife agency and with your city or county.

Red flags & finding a vet

What to watch for, what to tell the vet, and how to find one before you need one.

CONTACT A REPTILE VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

A juvenile refusing food for 2 to 3 days, or an adult for 1 to 2 weeks outside brumation, or any refusal with lethargy, abnormal stool or a swollen belly · tremors or muscle twitching · swelling in the jaw or limbs, limping, or trouble moving, climbing or lifting the body · labored or open-mouth breathing, or discharge from eyes, nose or mouth · a beard that stays dark for days · diarrhea, or runny or foul-smelling stool for more than 2 days · straining without producing waste, or no stool in 5+ days (3 in a juvenile that eats) · stargazing · any skin lesion or discoloration · swollen or bleeding gums, or cheesy material in the mouth · a toe or tail tip turning dark, dry or hard · eyes swollen or closed more than 2 days · blistered, blackened or peeling skin · sunken eyes · any tissue protruding from the vent · a gravid female digging or straining for more than 24 to 48 hours with no eggs.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Current basking and cool-side temps, and how you measured them
- ☐ UVB tube type, age, distance, and whether there's mesh in the way
- ☐ Diet breakdown (insects versus greens) and supplement schedule over the last 2 weeks
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Last normal bowel movement, and what it looked like
- ☐ Weight trend from the Owner Log, and a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag if you can

Why UVB and temperature come up first

MBD, respiratory infection, impaction and appetite loss trace back to a UVB or temperature problem more often than anything else, which is why a vet asks about your setup first.

Finding a reptile vet

Many dog and cat practices do not see reptiles, so find one before the first emergency. The Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians keeps a find-a-vet directory of its members. Ask a clinic how many reptiles it sees, whether it treats bearded dragons routinely, whether it runs fecal tests in house, and who covers emergencies after hours, then write the number on page 35. See the vet at least once a year, twice if your vet prefers; the yearly visit adds blood work (a blood count and a liver and kidney panel) to the exam and fecal test.

Normal or concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Black beard for a few hours during shedding, stress, or a territorial moment, then back to normal color	Black beard lasting multiple days, especially paired with lethargy or appetite loss
An adult skipping a meal occasionally, especially in cooler weather	A juvenile refusing food for more than 2 to 3 days, or an adult for more than 1 to 2 weeks outside brumation
Brief lethargy right after a big meal or during a shed cycle	Persistent lethargy with no clear trigger, or lethargy with weight loss
Dull, gray-looking skin for a few days before a shed	Yellow, crusty, or blackened patches of skin that spread

Metabolic bone disease

The most common serious illness in pet bearded dragons, and almost always preventable.

What it is: without enough usable calcium, the body pulls calcium out of the skeleton to keep the blood level steady, and the bones soften and bend. The veterinary name is nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism. **Cause:** insufficient UVB, insufficient calcium, too much phosphorus relative to calcium, or a dragon kept too cool to digest, over weeks to months. Juveniles under two are hit hardest because their bones are still forming, and a growing dragon builds every gram of new bone from calcium it can only absorb with vitamin D3.

STAGE	SIGNS
Early	Lower appetite and energy; less moving around; twitching toes, a slight tremor when held; reluctance to climb; a jaw that looks a little soft or receded
Later	A swollen or rubbery lower jaw; trouble walking, or no longer lifting the body clear of the floor; soft, bowed or swollen limbs; a bent or zigzag tail or spine; twitching that progresses to full muscle spasms; fractures from minor falls; cloacal prolapse (tissue from the vent)
Severe	Seizures

Diagnosis: physical exam plus an X-ray to check bone density, sometimes a blood calcium panel.

Response: vet diagnosis and treatment immediately. This does not self-correct and worsens quickly.

Treatment: correcting the lighting and the diet comes first, plus fluids, feeding support and injected calcium for a dragon already in crisis. Typical treatment cost runs \$200 to \$500 or more. **Recovery:** caught while the dragon is still eating, the outlook is good, and mild cases improve over weeks to months. Treatment does not straighten a jaw or limb that has already healed crooked, so a dragon that recovers from severe MBD usually keeps its shape for life.

WHILE YOU WAIT FOR THE APPOINTMENT

Remove climbing furniture and lower the basking platform. A dragon with weakened bones can fracture a limb in a fall that wouldn't hurt a healthy one. Handle as little as possible and support the whole body when you must.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

A T5 HO tube at the right distance, replaced on time (page 9), and the calcium schedule (page 17) prevent nearly all MBD. This is the single highest-leverage thing in this whole package. A coil bulb, a tube behind glass, or a tube past its replacement date are the usual ways it fails.

Impaction, dehydration & prolapse

Three problems that often travel together: a dry, cold or blocked gut, and the straining that follows.

Impaction

What it is: a blockage in the digestive tract. **Cause:** loose substrate, oversized or hard-shelled feeder insects, dehydration, or temperatures too low to digest properly. **Signs:** no droppings for several days despite still eating, straining without producing waste, a firm lump along the belly, lethargy, loss of appetite, and weakness or dragging in the hind legs. **Diagnosis:** the vet feels the belly and takes an X-ray to locate and size the blockage. **Recovery:** mild, early cases sometimes resolve with vet-guided warm soaks, fluids and gentle belly massage; a real blockage may need imaging, fluids or surgery.

CONCRETE THRESHOLD

If your dragon hasn't defecated in five or more days, or a juvenile that normally goes daily hasn't in three, it's time to see a vet. Don't wait longer to "see if it resolves." Surgery, when needed, commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500.

Dehydration

In a reptile, dehydration usually comes from a long stretch off food or no water it can reach, not from vomiting or diarrhea as in mammals. Chronically low calcium makes a dragon less able to cope with it.

SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

Wrinkled or loose skin outside a shed, sunken eyes, thick or stringy saliva, yellow or hard urates, lethargy, and skin that stays tented for a moment when gently pinched on the side. Mild cases respond to soaks and hydrating foods (page 33). A dragon that is sunken and lethargic needs a vet for fluids, not more soaking at home.

Prolapse

Pink or red tissue protruding from the vent that doesn't go back in on its own within a few minutes. It is a symptom of an underlying problem, not a condition on its own: dehydration, constipation, straining while laying eggs, and the muscle weakness of MBD are the usual triggers. Keep the tissue moist with a clean wet cloth or saline, never try to push it back in, and get to a vet the same day. It is always treated as an emergency.

Respiratory infection, atadenovirus & yellow fungus

Three conditions worth knowing by name before you ever see them.

Respiratory infection

Cause: most often an enclosure that is too cool, or humidity that sits high for days. **Signs:** open-mouth or labored breathing at rest, audible clicking or wheezing, mucus or bubbles at the nose or mouth, nasal discharge, cloudy eyes, puffing the throat repeatedly, lethargy, loss of appetite. **Diagnosis:** physical exam and listening to the lungs; the vet will ask about your temperature setup directly. **Response:** it can be fatal without treatment and needs prescription antibiotics, not a wait-and-see approach. Correct the temperature and humidity in parallel, or it recurs. Occasional gaping while basking is normal temperature control, not infection.

Atadenovirus (ADV)

What it is: a highly contagious virus, most often seen in young dragons, spread by direct contact and by droppings on shared tools, dishes, hands and enclosures. **Signs:** failure to thrive, stunted growth, chronic poor condition despite correct husbandry, weakness, paralysis, and neurological signs, most distinctively "stargazing," the head held tilted up and back. It causes fatal liver and gut disease. **Reality check:** there is no cure, only supportive care, and some infected adults show nothing while shedding the virus. A vet can test a new dragon with a PCR swab. Quarantine any new reptile for 3 to 6 months in a separate room with separate tools (page 22), and never share feeder tubs between animals.

Yellow fungus disease

What it is: a contagious, aggressive fungal skin infection caused by *Nannizziopsis guarroi*, long grouped under the older name CANV (short for *Chrysosporium anamorph of Nannizziopsis vriesii*). **Signs:** yellow, tan or brown discolored, crusty or thickened scales, often starting on the head, limbs or belly, sometimes with a foul odor, that spread and ulcerate over weeks. **Diagnosis:** skin biopsy or culture. **Response:** prompt, aggressive antifungal treatment for months, and strict isolation from other reptiles. The outlook ranges from guarded to grave (uncertain at best, often poor), so see a vet the day you notice the first patch. It spreads by contact and shared substrate or tools.

THE COMMON THREAD

All three are far less common in a correctly heated, correctly lit, single-dragon enclosure with good quarantine hygiene for anything new. Prevention here is mostly husbandry, not luck.

Parasites, mouth rot & eye problems

Less dramatic than the last page, and far more common.

Internal parasites

Pinworms and coccidia (single-celled gut parasites) turn up even in dragons from good breeders. A low pinworm count on its own often causes no real trouble in an adult; coccidia in a juvenile can trigger real illness fast. **Signs:** runny or foul-smelling stool, undigested food in the droppings, weight loss, poor appetite, lethargy. Loose stool is often the first sign, before foul-smelling stool and weight loss follow. Many infections show nothing at all, which is why testing beats waiting.

- **A fecal exam at the first vet visit and every year after** catches most of these before they get serious.
- **Bring a fresh sample**, less than 24 hours old, in a sealed bag. Older samples make some parasites harder to identify under the microscope.
- **Never deworm blindly** with an over-the-counter product. The dose depends on which parasite is present and the dragon's exact weight, and treating blind can underdose a real infection or dose a dragon that never needed it.

Mouth rot (infectious stomatitis)

Signs: swollen or bleeding gums, yellow-white cheesy material in the mouth, drooling, refusing food, a jaw that looks puffy on one side. Dark or stained teeth on their own are normal in adults. **Cause:** stress, low temperatures, a mouth injury from live prey or hard food, sometimes MBD. **Response:** a vet visit for cleaning and antibiotics, and not one to put off: left alone, the infection spreads into the jawbone.

Eye problems

Eyes held shut or a little puffy for a day or two during a head shed is normal. Swollen, closed or weeping eyes that last longer usually point to a UVB bulb too close or too strong (coil bulbs at short range are the classic cause), a vitamin A imbalance, a scratch, or an infection. Check the distance between the UVB tube and the basking spot first, since it is the most common cause and the easiest to rule out. See a vet if it persists past two days or comes with discharge.

Shedding, tail and toe rot & burns

Skin problems a weekly look catches early.

A normal shed

Juveniles shed far more often than adults. The skin looks dull and gray for a few days first, and appetite often dips. Help it along by raising humidity toward the top of the 30 to 40% range during the shed itself, not permanently, and by giving rough surfaces to rub on: cork bark, slate and branches.

Stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Most common on toes, the tail tip and around the eyes. Rings of old shed can tighten around a toe or tail tip and cut off its blood supply, and the damage builds across shed cycles. To loosen it, soak the dragon in water at enclosure temperature, chin-deep, for 30 minutes, supervised throughout, then ease the loose shed off a toe with a damp cotton swab. Never peel unshed skin by force. Low humidity is the usual cause but only one of six: skin parasites, poor nutrition, infection, nothing rough to rub on, and low thyroid function all do it too. Repeated bad sheds in a correct setup are a vet conversation, not a humidity problem.

Tail rot and toe loss

Signs: a toe or the tail tip turns dark, dry and hard, and the dark area creeps upward over the following days. **Cause:** stuck shed cutting off circulation is the most common, but a bite from a cage mate or an oversized feeder insect, or a fall, does the same damage. **Response:** vet promptly. Caught early it is often treatable; caught late, the tissue has died and the only option is amputating the affected section to stop it spreading. Bearded dragons don't regrow lost tail tissue, so whatever is amputated is permanent. Check toes and the tail tip at every shed.

Burns

Burns most often come from hot rocks, an unguarded bulb, or a basking surface running hotter than intended, and show as blistered, blackened or peeling skin, usually on the back or belly. Cool the area with room-temperature water and fix the heat source immediately. Anything more than a small red patch needs a vet, because reptile burns often look worse over the following days rather than better. Check the basking surface with the infrared thermometer on any new setup.

THE SHED CHECK

At every shed, look at each toe and the tail tip in good light. A thin ring of old skin is easy to soak off today, and a dark, dry toe tip next week is a vet visit.

Reading poop, urates & hydration

Stool is the earliest free health check you get. Look at it before you clean it up.

Urates are the white part of a reptile's droppings. Instead of liquid urine, the body turns nitrogen waste into uric acid, made in the liver from protein digestion, and passes it as a white to cream paste alongside the stool. Its color and texture are the fastest daily read on hydration you have.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
Firm brown log with a white to off-white soft urate	Normal	Nothing. Juveniles go about daily, adults every 1 to 4 days, less in brumation.
Urate yellow, orange, or hard and chalky	Dehydration, and left uncorrected a urate or kidney problem	Soak, mist the salad, offer hydrating foods. Vet if it persists a week or the dragon looks sunken: the same uric acid chemistry is what causes gout.
Runny, watery, or foul-smelling for more than 2 days	Parasites, especially if there's mucus; or too much fruit, hornworms, or watery greens	Cut the watery foods first. If it continues, vet with a fresh sample.
Whole recognizable insect parts. Fragments of chitin, the hard insect shell, are normal	Basking temperature too low, or prey too large	Re-measure the basking surface and downsize the insects.
Black, tarry, or with red streaks	Possible blood in the digestive tract	Vet the same day.
Only urate, no feces, for several days	Not eating, or brumation	Check appetite and temps against the refusal thresholds (page 27).
Nothing at all for 5+ days (3 in a juvenile that eats)	Possible impaction	Vet promptly.
Straining, with nothing passed	Constipation, a blockage, or a problem at the vent	Vet promptly; straining can end in a prolapse.

Hydration

Most of a dragon's water comes from food. Many barely touch a dish, some drink from one regularly, so keep a shallow dish available and refresh it daily. Beyond that:

- Mist the salad, not the enclosure walls. Water droplets on greens get eaten; a damp enclosure just raises humidity into the range that risks respiratory infection.
- A shallow lukewarm soak, 15 to 20 minutes, once or twice a week, chest-deep at most and never unsupervised. Most dragons drink during it.
- Hydrating foods: hornworms, silkworms, cucumber or melon pieces, cactus pad, as extras rather than staples.
- A dragon that won't drink: drip water onto the snout with a syringe or dropper and let it lick. Never squirt water into the mouth.

The number that matters is your own dragon's baseline. A real change from it, in how often, how it looks, or how it smells, is the signal, not any fixed count.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm) enclosure, front-opening (page 6)
- ☐ Linear T5 HO UVB tube 16 to 18 in (41 to 46 cm) above the basking spot, or 11 to 12 in (28 to 30 cm) through mesh, for a 12% tube; other strengths follow their own chart (page 9)
- ☐ Separate halogen or incandescent basking bulb (UVB alone won't provide heat)
- ☐ Dimming thermostat on the basking bulb, probe at basking level on a clip or suction cup (page 8)
- ☐ Plug-in timer for every light
- ☐ Infrared thermometer for surface temperature
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer on each end
- ☐ Basking platform and two hides (warm and cool)
- ☐ Paper towel, newspaper, or tile substrate (page 11)
- ☐ Shallow water dish and a food dish or slate
- ☐ Plain calcium, calcium with D3, and a reptile multivitamin (page 17)
- ☐ Feeding tongs and a kitchen scale that reads in grams
- ☐ Feeder insect supplier and a greens plan (pages 14 to 16)
- ☐ A plastic tub for cleaning gear, never the kitchen sink (page 12)

Temperature & climate targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Basking surface, adult / juvenile	95 to 110 / 105 to 115	35 to 43 / 41 to 46
Warm side (ambient, not basking)	about 90	about 32
Cool side	75 to 85	24 to 29
Nighttime low	65 to 75	18 to 24
Basking surface ceiling	never above 122	never above 50
Humidity	30 to 40% baseline	
UVI at basking spot	4.0 to 4.5 (3.0 or lower for hypomelanistic, silkback, and translucent morphs)	
Light cycle	12 to 14 hours summer, 10 to 12 hours winter, on a timer	

Before your dragon comes home

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up and running for 24 to 48 hours first
- ☐ Basking and cool-side temps confirmed with a thermometer, not by feel
- ☐ Thermostat tested: watch it dim the bulb as the probe warms
- ☐ UVB fixture mounted at the correct distance, its date logged (page 44)
- ☐ Feeder insect and greens source lined up before day one
- ☐ Reptile vet found and the first exam booked for the first 48 hours (page 22)

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

No stool in 5+ days (3 in a juvenile) · open-mouth breathing at rest, wheezing, or mucus · limb or jaw swelling, tremors, seizures, or inability to lift the body · sunken eyes with lethargy · a juvenile off food 2 to 3 days, an adult 1 to 2 weeks outside brumation · head held tilted up and back · tissue protruding from the vent · a female digging or straining more than 24 to 48 hours with no eggs · a burn, a spreading dark patch on tail or toes, or black or bloody stool

READING	°F	°C
Basking surface, adult / juvenile	95 to 110 / 105 to 115	35 to 43 / 41 to 46
Warm side (ambient)	about 90	about 32
Cool side	75 to 85	24 to 29
Nighttime low	65 to 75	18 to 24
Power outage floor (act if below it for a day or two)	60	16
Humidity	30 to 40%	
UVI at basking spot	4.0 to 4.5 (3.0 or lower for sensitive morphs)	
UVB bulb replacement	Every 6 to 12 months (T5 HO) · every 6 months (T8)	
Calcium	Plain near-daily for juveniles, 2 to 3× a week for adults · D3 version 2× a week · multivitamin 1 to 2× a week	

Your numbers

Reptile vet _____

UVB bulb installed _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

Replace UVB by _____

Dragon's name and hatch date _____

Last vet visit _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Basking and cool-side temps, UVB bulb type and age, last bowel movement and what it looked like, current weight and the trend, and diet over the last two weeks. Transport in a ventilated tub with a towel, kept warm (page 41).

Budget: setup & shopping list

United States retail ranges, rounded to the nearest \$5. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium enclosures and lighting.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
4×2×2 ft enclosure (PVC, or wood with a glass front); check the dimensions before you buy	\$200 to \$500
Linear T5 HO UVB fixture about two-thirds the enclosure length (check the length against your enclosure), tube included	\$110 to \$130
Halogen basking bulb and dome fixture	\$35 to \$100
Dimming thermostat	\$20 to \$35
Digital thermometer and hygrometer, plus an infrared temp gun	\$25 to \$80
Substrate (tile or paper towel)	\$5 to \$25
Hides, basking platform, branches and decor	\$40 to \$200
Hammock	\$10 to \$20
Shallow water dish	\$5 to \$15
Feeding tongs	\$5 to \$15
Kitchen scale that reads in grams	\$10 to \$15
First supply of plain calcium, calcium with D3 and a multivitamin	\$40 to \$55
Equipment, the budget pick to premium in every row	\$505 to \$1,190
First vet exam and fecal test	\$120 to \$245
All-in, before the dragon arrives	\$625 to \$1,435

Highly recommended, not in the total: a UV index meter, about \$240 to \$265, the only way to check the UVB tube's height and when it needs replacing; UV cards do not measure UVB.

The dragon itself is extra: \$40 to \$100 for a standard morph. A UVB tube's wattage is not its length: a slim high-output tube of 24 watts is about 22 in (56 cm) long, 39 watts about 34 in (86 cm), 54 watts about 46 in (117 cm). Match the length in inches to two-thirds of the enclosure.

Budget: monthly costs

What a bearded dragon costs to keep each month once the setup on the previous page is in place, on the same rounding.

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Feeder insects (less as an adult)	\$30 to \$60
Greens and vegetables	\$10 to \$25
Supplement top-ups	about \$10
Electricity for heat and lighting	\$10 to \$20
UVB tube replacement, averaged	\$5 to \$10
Annual wellness exam and fecal, averaged	\$10 to \$20
Monthly ongoing	\$75 to \$145

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Impaction surgery \$800 to \$2,500 · MBD treatment \$200 to \$500 or more. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The UVB fixture, the thermostat, and the enclosure size are the three line items most directly tied to the health conditions in this package. Save on decor before you save here. Substrate can cost next to nothing.

First 30 days

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the dragon in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ Confirm basking surface, cool side and night temps with the infrared gun and a digital thermometer, not "feels warm"
- ☐ Book the first exam with a reptile vet for within 48 hours, with a fresh stool sample under 24 hours old (page 22)
- ☐ If another reptile lives here, set up the separate quarantine room and its own tools
- ☐ Fill in the emergency card (page 35)
- ☐ Start the equipment dates (page 44)

Week 1

- ☐ Let your dragon settle: hands off except feeding and spot-cleaning (page 19)
- ☐ Watch appetite and stool every day
- ☐ Measure UVI with a meter if you have one, or verify the mounting distance (page 9)

Weeks 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short, gentle handling sessions if appetite and behavior look normal
- ☐ Settle into a consistent feeding and supplement schedule (page 17), and start the salad habit even if it's ignored
- ☐ Start the Owner Log with a weekly weigh-in (page 43)

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend: steady gain for a juvenile, stable weight for an adult (page 18)
- ☐ Set a phone reminder for the UVB replacement date and a monthly thermostat check
- ☐ Do the first monthly deep clean (page 12)
- ☐ Introduce the first enrichment items (page 45)

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and act on the fecal result if parasites showed up
- ☐ Re-measure UVI directly if you have a meter; don't rely on the bulb's age alone
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or temps
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet before you need it (page 42)
- ☐ Keep any quarantine running to the full 3 to 6 months before the dragon shares a room, tools or air with another reptile
- ☐ Recheck the sex at 6 months, and add a lay box if it's a female (page 23)

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Black beard plus lethargy	Stress, illness, or brumation	Check temps first; vet if it lasts days (page 20)
No stool 5+ days (3 in a juvenile)	Impaction	Vet promptly (page 29)
Twitching toes, tremors, soft or swollen jaw	Metabolic bone disease	Vet immediately; remove climbing items (page 28)
Open-mouth breathing at rest, wheezing, mucus	Respiratory infection	Vet promptly; fix temps and humidity (page 30)
Head tilted up and back, wobbling, failure to thrive	Atadenovirus or another neurological cause	Vet, isolate from other reptiles (page 30)
Yellow or crusty skin patches that spread	Yellow fungus	Vet the same day and isolate (page 30)
Swollen gums, cheesy material in mouth	Mouth rot	Vet (page 31)
Eyes swollen or closed more than 2 days	UVB too close or strong, vitamin A, infection	Check bulb distance; vet if it persists (page 31)
Tail tip or toe turning dark and dry	Tail rot, stuck shed	Vet promptly (page 32)
Stuck shed on toes or tail	Low humidity, nothing to rub on	30-minute soak, then a damp swab (page 32)
Blistered or blackened skin	Burn	Fix heat source; vet (page 32)
Pink or red tissue from the vent	Prolapse	Keep moist, vet same day (page 29)
Wrinkled skin, sunken eyes, yellow or hard urates	Dehydration	Soak and hydrating foods; vet if sunken and lethargic (page 29)
Runny or smelly stool 2+ days	Parasites, diet, stress	Cut watery foods; vet with fresh sample (page 33)
Repetitive glass scratching	Reflection, size, heat, boredom, gravid	Work the list (page 20)
Reduced appetite, adult, cooler months	Possible brumation	Vet check first, then let it happen (page 25)
Female digging, restless, off food	Gravid	Lay box now (page 23)
Female digging or straining more than 24 to 48 hours with no eggs	Egg binding	Vet the same day (page 24)
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet, bring the Owner Log (page 18)
Bulging head fat pads, jowls, belly dragging	Obesity	Cut fatty feeders, more salad and activity (page 18)
Gaping while basking, otherwise normal	Normal temperature control	Nothing, unless it comes with wheezing or mucus

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Read the warm-end and cool-end thermometers; a warm end that keeps climbing is the warning sign
- ☐ Salad and insects per the age schedule (page 13)
- ☐ Dust supplements on the right days (page 17)
- ☐ Wash and refill the water dish; remove uneaten insects before lights-out
- ☐ Spot-clean droppings, and look at them before you do (page 33)
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes, beard, posture, belly, appetite
- ☐ Wash your hands after every contact

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it (page 43)
- ☐ Wipe down glass, walls, dishes, decor and the basking platform
- ☐ Optional 15 to 20 minute soak, more often during a shed
- ☐ Check the basking surface with the infrared gun
- ☐ Rotate the greens so no single one is the whole salad

Monthly

- ☐ Deep clean: everything out, scrubbed, disinfected, rinsed, dried, fresh substrate (page 12)
- ☐ Confirm the thermostat still cuts in, the probe hasn't moved, and the timers are on schedule
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Reposition one furnishing; check climbing items still fit the dragon's size

Every 3 months

- ☐ Measure UVI with a meter if you have one; adjust height or replace the bulb
- ☐ Check nails and tail tip for overgrowth or old stuck shed

Seasonal

- ☐ Shift the timer: 12 to 14 hours of light in summer, 10 to 12 in winter
- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings; add night heat only if the room drops below 65°F (18°C)
- ☐ Watch for early brumation signs in fall, and book the pre-brumation vet check (page 25)
- ☐ Adult females: lay box ready from late winter through summer (page 23)

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam, fecal test and blood work; many reptile vets prefer twice a year (page 27)
- ☐ Replace the T5 HO tube by 12 months at the latest, sooner if the UVI has dropped (a T8 at 6 months)
- ☐ Replace opened powders by the date on the jar

Power outages, heat waves, travel & transport

A healthy adult tolerates one cool night without harm. The risk is days without heat, and feeding a dragon that can't digest.

When the power goes out

Do

- Aim to keep the dragon above 65°F (18°C); 60°F (16°C) is the floor, and a day or two below it is when problems start.
- Drape thick towels or a blanket over the enclosure, leaving a vent gap, to hold what heat is left.
- Move the enclosure, or the dragon in a tub, to the warmest room in the house.
- Use hand warmers or a hot-water bottle wrapped in a towel, placed beside the dragon, never touching it.
- Stop feeding insects. Offer greens and water only until the basking spot is back.
- Past a day or two below 60°F (16°C), board it with a vet, a friend with power, or a reptile shop.

Don't

- Don't use candles, gas stoves, or open flame anywhere near the enclosure.
- Don't put a heat pack in direct contact with the dragon; it can't move away fast enough and will burn.
- Don't feed insects "to keep its strength up." Undigested food in a cold gut rots.
- Don't warm a cold dragon in hot water; lukewarm only, and only once it's alert.

OUTAGE KIT

Hand warmers, a hot-water bottle, two thick towels, a battery thermometer, a ventilated tub, and your vet numbers written on paper.

In a heat wave

The cool end must stay at 75 to 85°F (24 to 29°C), so check it through the day: the thermostat can dim the basking bulb but cannot cool the room. Digging at the coolest corner, gaping, or sitting in the water means it is too hot. Keep the enclosure out of direct sun, which heats glass far faster than the room.

Leaving town

TRIP LENGTH	ADULT	JUVENILE (UNDER 12 MONTHS)
1 to 2 nights	Fine alone. Lights on timers, thermostat on, fresh salad and water before you go. No insects needed.	A sitter once a day for insects, greens, water, and a temperature check.
3 to 7 nights	A sitter every 1 to 2 days for greens, water, a stool check, and a temperature check. Insects twice in the week.	A sitter daily, with pre-portioned insects and written instructions.
Over a week	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a reptile-experienced vet or shop. Never a general dog-and-cat boarding facility. A dragon that is sick, mid-shed or gravid gets the juvenile column.	

Transport and vet trips

- A ventilated plastic tub or small carrier with a towel to grip, in a dark room-temperature bag or box. No loose substrate, no water dish.
- Warm the car before loading in cold weather; a wrapped hand warmer beside the tub for trips over 30 minutes below 65°F (18°C). Check the tub every 20 to 30 minutes at a stop.
- Don't feed insects the morning of a trip. Never leave the dragon in a parked car, hot or cold, even briefly.
- Moving house: set the enclosure up and running at the new place before the dragon arrives, same as day one.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Dragon's name _____

Age and normal weight _____

My phone _____

Reptile vet _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- ☐ Check the thermometers. Warm end should read about 90°F (32°C), cool end 75 to 85°F (24 to 29°C). Lights should be on between _____ and _____.
- ☐ Fresh chopped salad in the dish: _____ (see the bag in the fridge). Throw out yesterday's.
- ☐ Insects on these days: _____. Give about _____ from the tub, one at a time with the tongs. Remove any left after 15 minutes.
- ☐ Dust with the calcium jar on _____ (light coating on the insects or salad).
- ☐ Rinse and refill the water dish.
- ☐ Scoop any poop with a paper towel. Normal is a brown log with a white end.
- ☐ Wash your hands before and after. Don't rinse anything in the kitchen sink.

Please don't

- Take the dragon out of the enclosure, unless we agreed on it. It can jump from your hands and doesn't know it can't fly.
- Change any dial, timer, or thermostat setting, or move the lights.
- Feed anything not on this sheet, and never lettuce, fruit, or anything from the garden.
- Spray the enclosure with water; a damp tank is bad for it.

CALL ME IF

The lights are off during the day or the warm end reads below 80°F (27°C) · the dragon is breathing with its mouth open at rest, or there's mucus at the nose · it hasn't moved from the same spot on two visits · the beard has been black all visit · there's runny or bloody poop, or none for three days · anything is protruding from the tail end · it's digging frantically and won't stop · anything else that looks wrong. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

One row a week. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	BASKING	COOL SIDE	APPETITE	STOOL	NOTES (SHED, MOOD, ENRICHMENT)

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady weight trend is the single best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a weight change before anything else is visible. Sixteen rows is four months; that's long enough to see a real trend.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
UVB bulb (6 to 12 months for T5 HO)			
Basking bulb			
Thermostat function check (monthly)			
Thermometer and hygrometer batteries			
UVI reading at basking spot			
Calcium and multivitamin opened (replace yearly)			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Month 1 is whichever month you start in.

TASK, BY MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Thermostat check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
UVI reading	☐			☐			☐			☐		
UVB bulb replaced						☐						☐
Vet exam and fecal	☐					☐						☐
Timer shifted for season			☐						☐			

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Climbing branches or ledges at two or more heights, securely anchored
- ☐ Basking platform the dragon can fully stretch out on
- ☐ Dig box, 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) of topsoil and play sand
- ☐ Lay box available for adult females in season (page 23)
- ☐ At least two hides at different enclosure temperatures
- ☐ Partial visual barrier on the busy side of the room

Monthly review

- ☐ Reposition one furnishing to refresh the layout
- ☐ Offer a scatter-feed, a hung salad, or a supervised insect hunt at least once
- ☐ Supervised free-roam in a warm, escape-proof room at least once
- ☐ Reassess whether climbing and basking items still fit current body size
- ☐ Try one new staple green (page 15)

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

FREE-ROAM SAFETY, EVERY TIME

Warm room, no drafts, gaps under furniture blocked, other pets out, cords and houseplants out of reach, and a hand within grabbing distance of any height. Back in the enclosure at the first sign of cooling, panic, or a black beard.

Glossary, A to H

ADV	Atadenovirus: a contagious, incurable virus of bearded dragons, worst in young ones, spread by contact and droppings. Stargazing is the sign to know. Pages 22, 30.
Arm-wave	A slow, circular roll of one front leg, most likely a sign of submission to a more dominant animal. Page 20.
Basking surface	The platform under the heat lamp where the dragon warms up: 95 to 110°F (35 to 43°C) for an adult, 105 to 115°F (41 to 46°C) for a juvenile, read with an infrared thermometer. Page 7.
Bioactive	A planted enclosure with a living substrate and a cleanup crew of isopods and springtails, tiny invertebrates that break down waste. Page 11.
Brumation	A reptile's natural winter slowdown: less activity and appetite for weeks to months, distinct from illness. Page 25.
CANV	Chrysosporium anamorph of Nannizziopsis vriesii: an old umbrella name for the fungi now split into several species, including the one behind yellow fungus. Page 30.
Captive-bred	Hatched from parents kept by people rather than caught in the wild. Every bearded dragon lawfully sold outside Australia is captive-bred. Pages 5, 26.
Ceramic heat emitter	A screw-in heater that gives off heat with no visible light, so it can run at night. Page 8.
Coccidia	Single-celled gut parasites. Common, and able to make a juvenile seriously ill fast. Found with a fecal test. Page 31.
D3, vitamin D3	The form of vitamin D a dragon makes in its skin under UVB and needs to absorb calcium. It builds up in the body, so more from supplements is not safer. Pages 9, 17.
Deep heat projector	A heater like a ceramic emitter that sends its heat down in a more focused beam, with no visible light. Page 8.
Dig box	A tub of slightly damp topsoil and play sand, 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) deep, for digging. Page 21.
Dimming thermostat	A thermostat that lowers the power to a heat bulb instead of switching it off and on. The right kind for halogen and incandescent basking bulbs. Page 8.
Dysecdysis	Incomplete or "stuck" shedding, most often on the toes, the tail tip and around the eyes. Page 32.
Dystocia	Egg binding: a female unable to pass her eggs. A same-day emergency. Page 24.
Fatty liver disease	Fat building up in the liver, the long-term risk of an overweight dragon fed like a juvenile. Page 18.
Fecal test	A vet's microscope check of a stool sample for parasites. Bring a sample less than 24 hours old in a sealed bag. Pages 22, 31.
Femoral pores	A row of waxy pores along the underside of the thighs, larger in adult males. Page 23.
Ferguson Zone	One of four groups that match a species' natural sun exposure to a UVB strength. Bearded dragons are Zone 3, open or partial-sun baskers. Page 9.
Glass surfing	Repetitive pacing or scratching along the glass, usually a sign something in the setup is wrong. Page 20.
Goitrogens	Compounds in kale, cabbage and broccoli that interfere with the thyroid in large, regular amounts. Fine in rotation, not as a daily staple. Page 15.
Gravid	Carrying eggs. Females can be gravid without ever meeting a male. Page 23.
Gut-loading	Feeding feeder insects a calcium-rich diet for 24 to 72 hours before offering them, so the nutrition passes through. Page 14.
Hemipenal bulges	The two bumps at the base of a male's tail, visible with a flashlight from about 4 to 6 months of age. Page 23.
Hypomelanistic	A morph with reduced dark pigment. Like silkback and translucent morphs, it burns more easily under UVB and gets a UVI of 3.0 or lower. Page 5.

REFERENCE

Glossary, I to Z

Impaction	A blockage in the digestive tract, often from loose substrate, oversized prey, dehydration, or a basking spot too cool to digest. Page 29.
Infrared thermometer	A handheld gun that reads the temperature of a surface from a distance. The way to check the basking surface. Page 7.
K (kelvin)	The scale for the color of light. A 6500 K lamp gives white, daylight-colored light. Page 9.
Lay box	A deep box of damp topsoil and sand, 6 to 12 in (15 to 30 cm), where a female digs and lays. Page 23.
LED	Light-emitting diode: a low-heat, long-life lamp. A daylight LED adds bright light, but no UVB and no basking heat. Page 9.
MBD	Metabolic bone disease: weakened, deformed bones from too little UVB or calcium, the most common serious illness in pet bearded dragons. Page 28.
Morph	A captive-bred line that looks different from the natural dragon in color, pattern or skin. Page 5.
Mouth rot	Infectious stomatitis: an infection of the gums and mouth that spreads to the jawbone if ignored. Page 31.
Oxalates	Compounds in spinach, chard, beet greens and parsley that bind calcium so it can't be absorbed. Why those foods are rare, not staple. Page 15.
PCR	Polymerase chain reaction: a lab test that detects a germ's genetic material from a swab. How a vet tests a dragon for ADV. Page 22.
Photoperiod	The number of hours of light per day: 12 to 14 in summer, 10 to 12 in winter, set by a timer. Page 8.
Probe	The thermostat's sensor. At the dragon's level at the basking platform, held with a clip or suction cup, never tape. Page 8.
Prolapse	Tissue pushed out of the vent that doesn't go back in within minutes. Keep it moist and see a vet the same day. Page 29.
Pulse proportional thermostat	A thermostat that sends short pulses of power to hold a steady temperature. Suits a ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector. Page 8.
PVC	Polyvinyl chloride: a rigid, waterproof plastic used for enclosure panels. Holds heat better than glass. Pages 6, 36.
Quarantine	Keeping a new reptile fully apart from others, in a separate room with separate tools, for 3 to 6 months. Page 22.
<i>Salmonella</i>	Bacteria that healthy reptiles carry in the gut and shed in droppings without being ill. Spread hands to mouth. Page 12.
Stargazing	Holding the head tilted up and back for long periods. A neurological sign, most often linked to ADV. Urgent, not wait-and-see. Page 30.
T5 HO	A fluorescent tube 5/8 inch across (T5), in the high-output (HO) version. The standard UVB source for this species; coil and compact bulbs are not equivalent. Page 9.
T8	An older fluorescent tube 1 inch across, weaker than a T5 HO and replaced every 6 months. Page 9.
Units	°F, degrees Fahrenheit, and °C, degrees Celsius, for temperature; in (inches), ft (feet) and cm (centimeters) for size; g (grams) for weight; % (percent) for humidity and UVB strength.
Urate	The white, paste-like part of reptile waste, made from uric acid instead of liquid urine. Its color and texture are a hydration gauge. Page 33.
UVB	Ultraviolet B: the part of sunlight a dragon's skin needs to make vitamin D3 and absorb calcium. Ordinary bulbs and window glass give none. Page 9.
UVI	Ultraviolet index: a measure of UVB strength at one spot, read with a handheld meter. 4.0 to 4.5 at the basking spot for this species. Page 9.
VCA	Veterinary Centers of America, now VCA Animal Hospitals: an animal hospital chain whose pet care articles are among this package's sources.
Yellow fungus	<i>Nannizziopsis guarroi</i> (historically grouped as CANV), a contagious, aggressive fungal skin infection. Page 30.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references

- VCA Animal Hospitals: the bearded dragon feeding, housing, diseases, problems, owning and brumation articles; reptile dystocia; the new reptile and annual reptile visits; choosing a pet reptile. The 48-hour first exam, the annual workup, egg binding, brumation and the healthy-dragon checks.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: nutritional and metabolic, parasitic, viral, reproductive and bacterial diseases of reptiles; management and husbandry; emergencies; clinical procedures; selecting a reptile; routine health care; cleaning and disinfection. Thermostat control, the 3 to 6 month quarantine, prolapse, and the bleach dilution.
- University of California, Davis, School of Veterinary Medicine: Bearded Dragon Care. North Carolina State University Veterinary Hospital: How to Feed Your Bearded Dragon.
- Washington State University Veterinary Teaching Hospital: Yellow Fungus Disease in Bearded Dragons. DoveLewis Emergency Animal Hospital: cloacal prolapse in reptiles.
- Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians: the find-a-vet directory.
- Kevin Wright, veterinarian, in Reptiles Magazine: diagnosing and treating retained shed. The 30-minute soak and the six causes of a bad shed.

Research

- Oonincx, Stevens, van den Borne, van Leeuwen and Hendriks (2010), Comparative Biochemistry and Physiology Part B 156: vitamin D3 supplementation and UVB exposure in juvenile bearded dragons.
- Baines and colleagues (2016), Journal of Zoo and Aquarium Research 4(1): How much UV-B does my reptile need? The Ferguson Zone framework.
- Smith and colleagues (2016), Proceedings of the Royal Society B: color change on different body regions in bearded dragon lizards.
- Finke (2002 and 2013), Zoo Biology: the nutrient content of feeder insects. Allen and Oftedal (1989) and Klasing and colleagues (2000), Journal of Zoo and Wildlife Medicine: raising feeder calcium by diet.

Public health

- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Healthy Pets, Healthy People, reptiles and amphibians, and the 2025 *Salmonella* outbreak linked to pet bearded dragons. Center for Food Security and Public Health, Iowa State University: reptile- and amphibian-associated salmonellosis, and isolation and quarantine areas.

Husbandry, equipment and the law

- ReptiFiles: bearded dragon temperatures and UVB, and atadenovirus. Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals: bearded dragon care and safe handling.
- Arcadia Reptile and Zoo Med Laboratories: T5 UVB distance and replacement guidance, and tube lengths and wattages. Spyder Robotics, thermostat manual: probe placement and the warning against tape.
- Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6.5; District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j); New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4; Maine Department of Inland Fisheries and Wildlife, Unrestricted Species List; Minnesota Statutes § 97A.401; West Virginia Code § 20-2-13; and each other state's rules, read on 1 October 2026 (Maine on 5 September 2026). Australian Government, Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water: wildlife trade and the law.
- Beastly Facts guides, current at publication: the bearded dragon enclosure setup, cost, feeding, safe foods, handling, health issues, brumation, eggs and egg binding, enrichment, growth and weight checks, shopping list and legal guides, the UVB and bioactive articles, and the cross-species reptile quarantine, heating and thermostats, UVB lighting, emergency plan, stool and urates, gut-loading, *Salmonella* and hygiene, and shedding guides. Prices were last checked in September and October 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Juvenile feedings	Once daily; once to twice daily (veterinary guidance)	Once daily
Juvenile salad	Every other day (veterinary schedules); daily (a specialist reference)	Daily, every other day at minimum
Hatchling feedings	2 to 3 a day (veterinary sources); 3 to 5 a day (hobby care sheets)	2 to 3 a day
An adult off food	Seek care after 1 to 2 days (a veterinary teaching hospital); a healthy adult can fast 1 to 2 weeks (a veterinarian-reviewed source)	Watch from day one; vet at 1 to 2 weeks, or at once with lethargy, abnormal stool or a swollen belly
Gut-loading	24 to 48 hours; up to 72 (a veterinary hospital)	24 to 72 hours, 48 typical
Quarantine	3 to 6 months (veterinary); 60 to 90 days (a hobby floor)	3 to 6 months
First vet exam	Within 48 hours (a veterinary hospital chain); within 72 hours and no later than two weeks (a reptile vet-visit guide)	Within 48 hours
Thermostat probe under a lamp	Makers split between the basking surface and the air a few inches below the bulb; veterinary references give no position	At the dragon's level at the basking platform, as your controller's manual specifies
UVB tube life	6 to 12 months by model; one maker rates both its T5 HO and T8 tubes at 12 months	The maker's schedule, never past 12 months for a T5 HO; a T8 every 6 months
Soaks	15 to 20 minutes chest-deep, for hydration; 30 minutes chin-deep at enclosure temperature, to loosen stuck shed (a reptile veterinarian)	Both, each for its own job

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 4.1 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **4.1, Oct 2026.** Safety: every perch and hide top kept at or below the UVB tube's chart distance; tube 10 to 14% to its own chart. Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$505 to \$1,190, monthly \$75 to \$145, the budget now over two pages. Other changes are wording only.
- **4.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 50 pages. Safety: hatchlings under about 1 month fed 2 to 3 times daily, 1 to 4 months twice daily, juveniles to 18 months once daily with a fresh salad every day, adults insects a few times a week; plain calcium near-daily for juveniles; multivitamin 1 to 2 times a week; feeders gut-loaded 24 to 72 hours on calcium-rich foods; setup checklist UVB distance corrected to 16 to 18 in; stuck shed loosened with a 30-minute chin-deep soak; handling sessions built up to 10 to 15 minutes; egg binding is a vet visit after more than 24 to 48 hours of digging or straining. Legal: a new page on the law in all 52 jurisdictions. Other changes are wording only.
- **3.2, Oct 2026.** Safety: first vet exam within 48 hours; *Salmonella* precautions for children under 5, adults 65 and older, anyone with a weakened immune system; calcium with D3 twice weekly for adults; outage floor 60°F (16°C); probe clipped, never taped; lamps 4 to 6 in above, basking surface under 122°F (50°C); UVB 16 to 18 in, 11 to 12 through mesh; yellow fungus, vet at the first patch. Costs: updated. Other changes are wording only.
- **3.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: quarantine for a new reptile now 3 to 6 months; discolored urates no longer blamed on excess calcium. Other changes are wording only.
- **3.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 34 pages. Safety: plain calcium daily, with D3 as a backup.
- **2.0, Aug 2026.** Second edition, 22 pages. Replaced by 3.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home. The law page is a summary as of October 2026, not legal advice.

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